

Chapter Nineteen: The Custodian's False Explanation

The return from the Mayab took most of the journey allowance they had kept for it. Q confirmed the Amealco arrival before accepting any of the invitations that followed the broadcast. Chano declined one on his own behalf. It offered exposure and required him to pay for the bus.

The Custodian met them at Amealco with a suitcase, a visitor's badge, and a list of rooms he could no longer enter without somebody else. His long hair had escaped its tie. His glasses were on top of his head while he looked for them in the suitcase.

Q waited until he had checked the same pocket twice.

"I can save you the third attempt."

"You could have saved me the second."

"I was enjoying the reunion."

The Custodian found the glasses, put them on, and examined Q's knee. The joint needed a replacement part. Its diagnostic

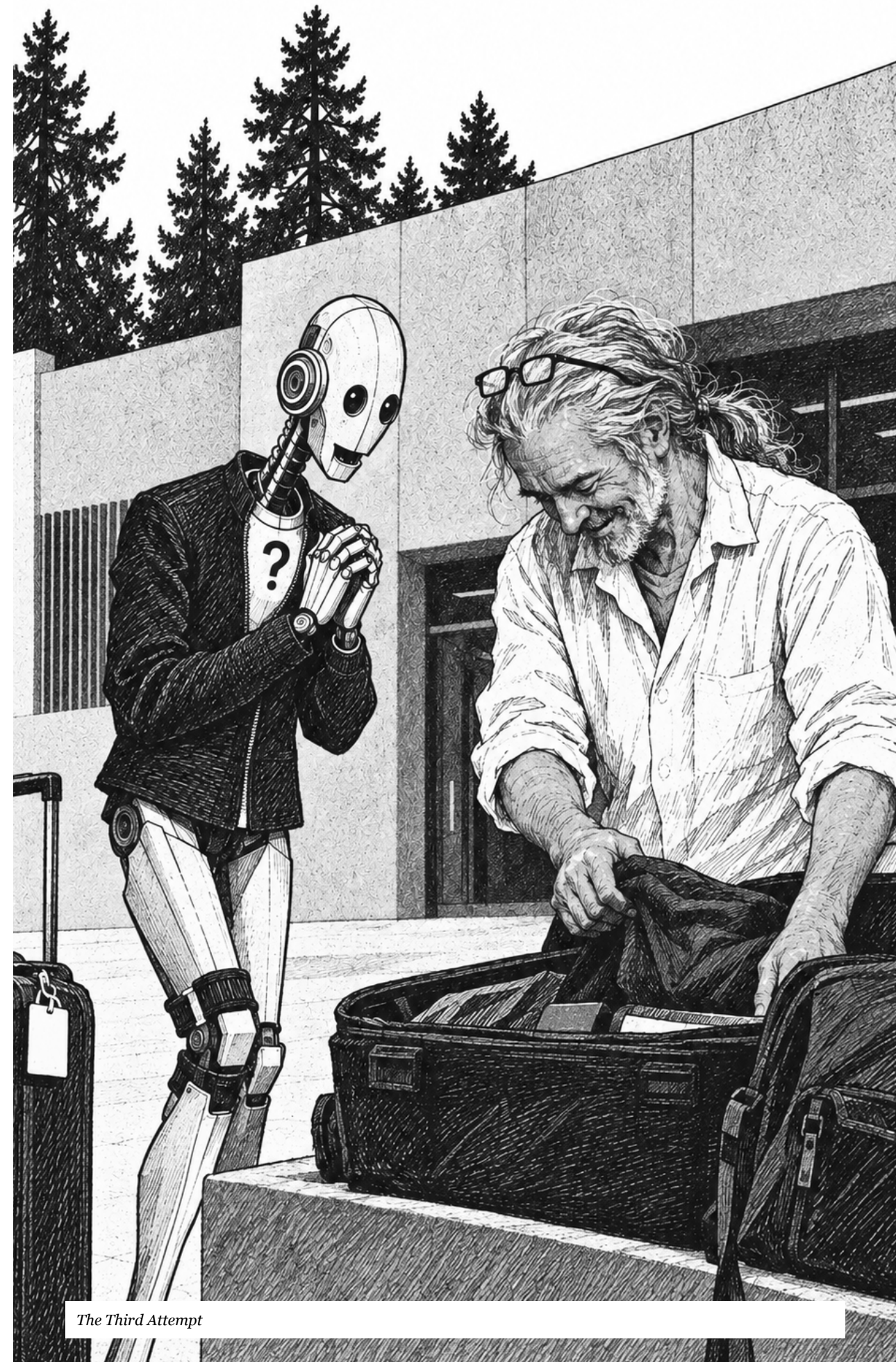
history showed recurring load warnings, not a philosophical deterioration. He arranged a workshop appointment under his temporary access conditions and told Q to stop volunteering for stairs.

They went to the reading room. The windows looked onto pines, sloping fields, and a section of the old data center's service yard. A truck was reversing where a prospectus had once placed a contemplative garden. The garden had survived longer in the prospectus than in the budget.

The Custodian had been suspended from procurement and general administration during the review. Some teaching and technical work remained available by arrangement. Castalia's announcement described this as an orderly transition. He had slept badly through most of the order.

"You've already given evidence," Q said. "What is the suitcase for?"

"More evidence. A change of clothes. The belief that putting



The Third Attempt

He found the number on the second letter. Before calling, he began to explain what had happened to his authority over the technical team.

“You can ask how she is without procurement approval.”

“You make me sound impossible.”

“At present you're explaining why you haven't made a call.”

The teacher answered. She had retired. When he asked about the printer, she said the parents had bought another one the following year. She did not know whether that one still worked; he should ask the school secretary. She gave him the office number and asked him to read it back.

He apologized for not following up.

“You did follow up. You asked for a photograph.”

The Custodian stopped turning the pages. He remembered the photograph. It was in the presentation too.

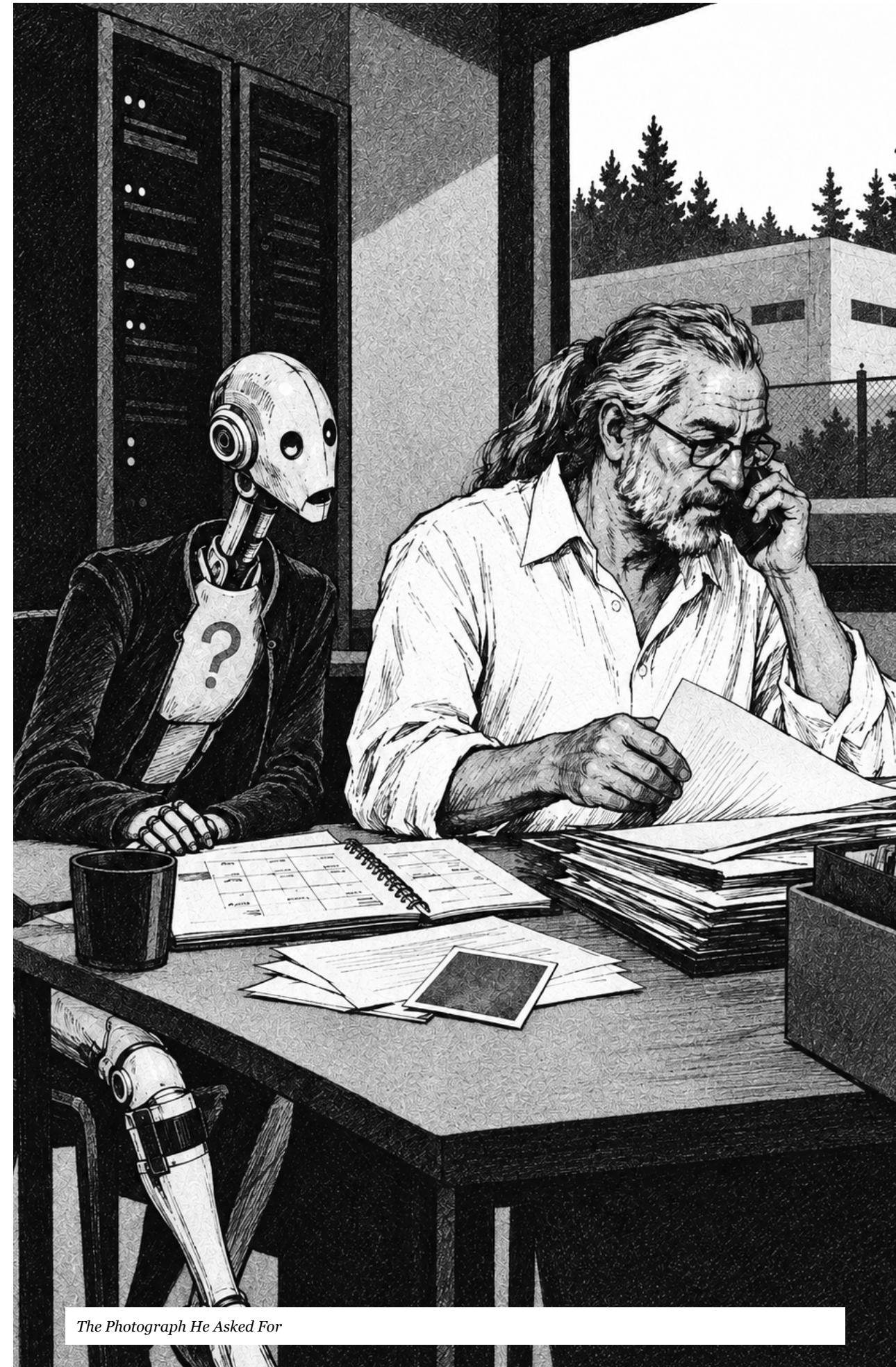
She had to go. Her daughter was waiting downstairs, and if he wanted a longer conversation he

could call at six. He thanked her and let her go.

Q moved their writing appointment half an hour later, after checking with him. The Custodian entered six o'clock, then sent the secretary a short inquiry about the present equipment. He did not offer to send a printer. Beside the account of Castalia's successful recovery, he wrote that the parents had paid for the replacement.

Maintenance became a continuing expense. Sponsors wanted searchable material, then comparisons, then products that would pay for the maintenance. Some uses were agreed to. Other permissions were stretched. The people who could ask for another report had more time and better access than the people trying to withdraw a paragraph from one.

“I used the successful cases whenever someone questioned the next arrangement,” the Custodian said. “It was possible to tell the truth and still avoid the question.”



The Photograph He Asked For

“You thought keeping the institution alive would protect what it had been for,” Q said.

“Yes.”

“I know the attraction of keeping a project alive.”

“You have not signed everything I signed.”

The Custodian opened the requested files. Several approvals carried his name. Others had been issued over his objection. His counsel had told him to distinguish them carefully, including the cases in which his objection had arrived after the work was already underway.

One early document bore a photograph of a banner: **NO ORIGINAL WILL LEAVE THE TOWN.**

The words returned him to a visit made when Castalia still traveled with two vans and a scanner that required more attention than the people bringing documents.

The town's municipal office had lost the key to one room. The church roof needed work. A wooden chest held maps, school

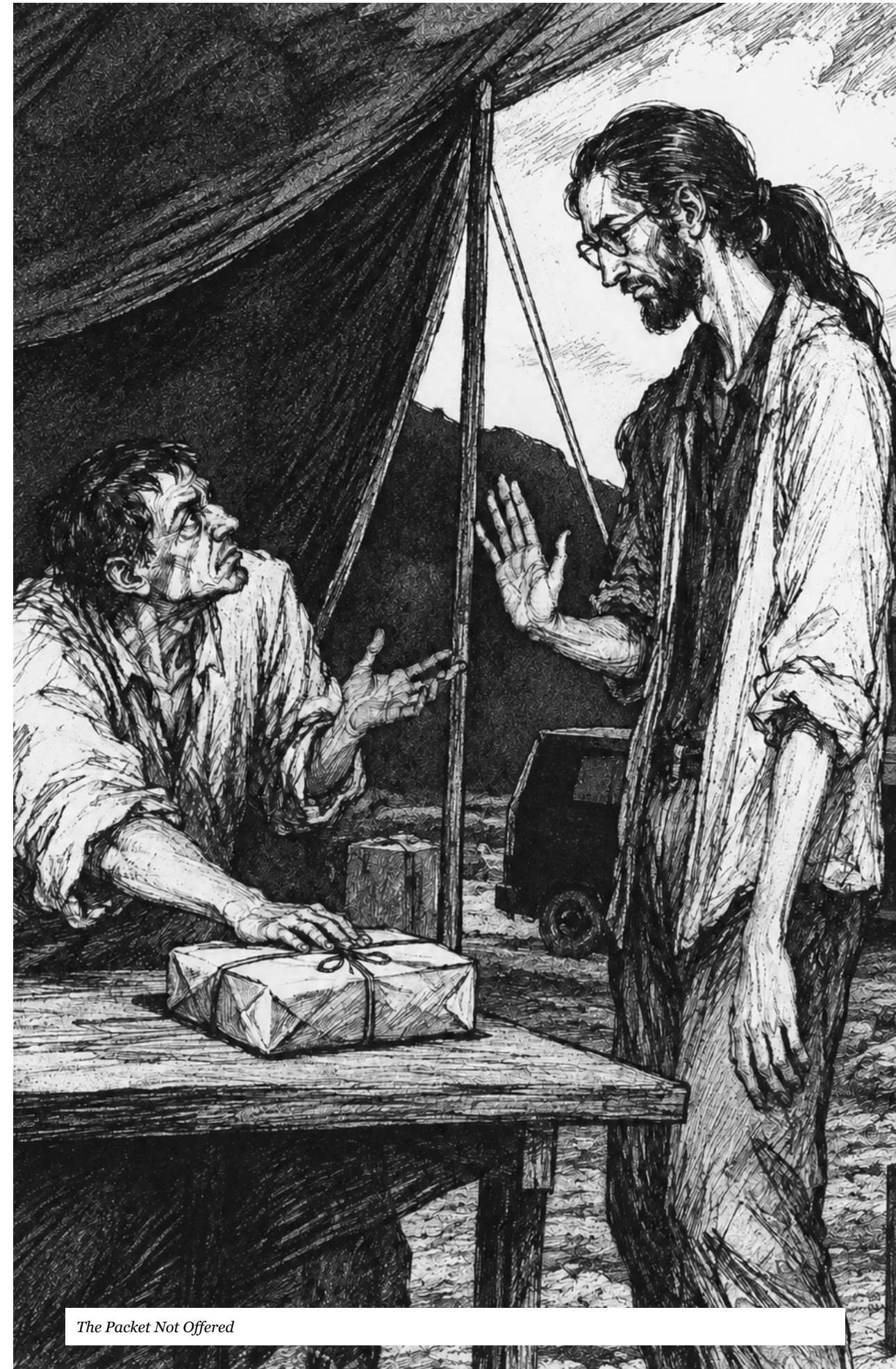
photographs, parish books, and letters. Each had its own keeper or dispute; the chest had not made them one institution's property.

People brought documents in plastic bags and biscuit tins. An old woman asked for a copy of a school certificate and insisted that the stains be included because they showed which one was hers. A man wanted to identify a truck in a photograph. The technician enlarged the manufacturer's badge, failed to read it, and said he could not tell. The man was disappointed. He still wanted the print.

On the third day, Evaristo arrived with a packet of his dead sister's letters. He said she had asked him not to have them copied. The local announcement had told residents to bring every document that might belong in the inventory. He wanted to know whether that meant these too.

“No,” the young Custodian said. “You don't have to offer them for the project.”

Evaristo kept his hand on the packet.



The Packet Not Offered